
On the Ethical Implications of Vogel's Environmental Philosophy

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[...] One time I threw a **candy wrapper** on the street. [...] I was with a friend, who said to me, "You just littered on the street! Don't you care about the environment?". And I thought about it and I said, "You know what this isn't the environment. This is New York City! *This is not the environment, this is where people live.*"

— Louis C.K., from *Live at the Beacon Theater*

Introduction

Built on the framework of the land ethic of Aldo Leopold, the tradition of environmental philosophy is considered to be concerned about the well-being of nature. In particular, it recognizes that phenomena such as pollution, toxic waste, water shortages, global warming and resource depletion¹ are instances of the fact there is something wrong with the world we live in; that we are at the very least partially responsible for such environmental problems, and that such environmental problems need to be remedied, by who else but humanity.

This boils down to saying that in some sense the world we live in must be protected from the wrongdoings of a particular one of its inhabitants, and must be protected by the very same inhabitants, where in the former the inhabitants are considered to be destructive and in the latter constructive. Yet this understanding seems to be echoing the infamous Cartesian duality of mind and body, and hence is problematic. The claim "the city is not the environment, the city is where people live" and the intuition that the environment needs to be protected can not be taken seriously at the same time. It seems deranged to say that pollution in the city is not a problem, while pollution in water resources is.

In his book *Thinking like a Mall*, Steven Vogel sets forth to fortify environmental philosophy, and for this purpose he goes on to debunk prominent environmental philosophies by way of claiming that the concept of nature is too ambiguous to be efficiently utilized in environmental philosophy. Instead of nature, he suggests that environmental philosophy ought to be concerned about the **environment**², which quite literally is defined to be that which environs us. Observe that this is in exact opposition to C.K.'s identification of the environment with not where people live. Due to his particular manner of discourse, he is bound to rework this idea into different languages, all more or less equivalent to each other. Among the languages he adopts are political theory and ontology, though since I am particularly interested in the ethical implications of his philosophy I will focus on his claim rendered in the language of ethics. To be

¹[Vog15, p. 30]

²Throughout this essay **bold** will denote the phrase defined by the sentence it is in.

specific, he prefers to package his philosophy into the language of a virtue ethicist, and declares two environmental virtues: knowledge and humility. **The virtue of knowledge** is the acknowledgment that humans are in the environment if and only if they transform it. **The virtue of humility** is the acknowledgment that humans are in the environment if and only if they can not transform it precisely as they hoped to. In other words, the virtue of knowledge requires one to acknowledge that he is capable, or doomed, to change his surroundings; while the virtue of humility requires one to acknowledge that his capabilities is, or doomed to be, limited.

Rephrasing his environmental virtue of knowledge, Vogel claims that his debunking of the prominent environmental philosophies itself is the primordial step in solving environmental problems. That is to say, the environmental vice of ignorance itself is an environmental problem, although perhaps not on the same level, in the sense of their solutions being physically observable, as the environmental problems that are phenomena, such as kids developing asthma due to air pollution:

[T]he appeal to nature turns out not merely to be unhelpful for environmental thinking but may in itself be harmful to that thinking. I will argue that the view of nature as something that needs to be protected because of its independence from human beings may itself be a central part of the environmental problems we face today.³

In this essay I will first explore the roots of Vogel's environmental philosophy in Leopold's land ethic, so that it is justified that Vogel's environmental philosophy is in the same tree of evolution (of philosophical theories) as the ones he criticizes, and consequently the relevance of his philosophy to the tangible environmental problems are conserved. I acknowledge that he does a better job than his predecessors in reshaping philosophical (among political and ontological) machinery into machinery that can actually be used in solving environmental problems, and that he accomplishes to continue Leopold's ethical sequence in a more natural manner than them. However it seems at first that what he ends up with has very little, if any, significance to actually remedying tangible environmental problems. One might say that even though Vogel's work is certainly a step forward by itself, the whole corpus of all environmental philosophy considered with Vogel's work at the end is taking no steps forward at all, in terms of beneficence of philosophy to environmental endeavors. Vogel's philosophy is philosophy undone. Indeed, all that Vogel does is to simply untangle the intellectual knots philosophy created by way of shying away from practice: it is intuitive that something should be done about, say, a polluted river, e.g. collect all the trash swimming in it, and yet committing to philosophy requires one to first question why this should be the case. The problem I am raising here is very much in line with what Arne Næss' deep ecology seeks to remedy, by both providing a template for a personal philosophy and practical action.

Considering Vogel's work, this problem arises because Vogel takes doing philosophy simply as practice, and he does not provide any distinction among various practices of humans,

³[Vog15, p. 31]

e.g. between, writing a book that repeats one simple idea and breaking a window by throwing a book at it. To be clear, Vogel does not take every practice to be the same kind, and surely it is not his primary purpose to give a genealogy of labor in *Thinking like a Mall*. However at the very least his own particular brand of philosophy should be argued to be a valid kind of practice. This is the second thing I will try to accomplish in this essay. To clarify that philosophy, especially the kind Vogel produced and quite possibly the kind contrary to the kinds he criticizes, is practice, and it is valuable practice for environmental endeavors, I will make use of Voltaire's *Candide*, where Voltaire has Candide (among others) suffer (in an absurd manner) through a journey by the end of which he comes to realize one needs not to say a word. This is the right way to approach this problem, especially since we are committed to developing the land ethic, as *Candide* too is philosophy undone.

Outline of the Land Ethic

Leopold's land ethic is best understood as a link in what he calls **the ethical sequence**, by which it is meant an increasing sequence of classes of things, whose members are thought to be worthy of ethical consideration. The first link establishes the interpersonal relations, the second link establishes relations between the individual and social level, and the third one is what Leopold calls land ethic:

The land ethic simply enlarges the boundaries of the community to include soils, waters, plants, and animals, or collectively: the land.⁴

The first link can be considered to be against slavery, and the second link against monarchy. In a similar way, the land ethic questions the slave-master relationship conceived to be between the land and the man. It is not the case that man can force total domination over the rest of the land, he is never sure about "what makes the community clock tick, and just what and who is valuable, and what and who is worthless"⁵, and quite possibly he never will be. This is what Vogel calls the virtue of humility.

And yet, our relation to the land is not the same as the relation anything else has to the land. Humans are not broccolis: we are capable of producing artifacts, some wonderful—like mathematics—and some dreadful—like a nuclear bomb. Some other species can produce some of the artifacts we produce as well, but the production of our most astonishing and/or dreadful products are exclusively by us. It is humans that make great mathematicians, not monkeys, *though we do produce some very good climbers*⁶. What is more, this potential of ours to produce artifacts immanent to our presence in the world, otherwise it makes no sense to talk about the relation between the land and humans. Even if one chooses to be as rigid

⁴[Leo49]

⁵[Leo49]

⁶[Tay81]

as a rock in terms of being part of a class of things in the ethical sequence, and consequently does nothing (consciously at least), he is still doing a thing unique to humans: he refrains from his potential. Though we are in a general agreement regarding something should be done. Likewise undoing, or restoration, is again a thing unique to humans. This is what Vogel calls the virtue of knowledge, "or more precisely *self-knowledge*"⁷. Vogel's roots in land ethics is henceforth clear.

Vogel's Post-Natural Environmental Philosophy

Now that I have established the land ethic roots of Vogel's philosophy, an explanation regarding why the replacement of the concept of nature with the concept of environment is naturally (or canonically) necessary after the land ethic. Vogel argues that there are at least four different senses in which the concept of nature seems to denote:

N1 (¬ Supernatural) In this sense **nature** is the "sum total of all phenomena"⁸. Vogel denotes this sense by writing the word with a capital N.

N2 (¬ Man Made) In this sense **nature** is defined to be "the nonhuman world, the world from which human action and its products have been excluded"⁹. Vogel denotes this sense by writing the word with a small n. Observe that this sense also coincides with how C.K. uses the term "environment": The environment, according to him, is precisely where people don't live.

N3 (Life) In this sense **nature** means "the *biological* world, the world of flora and fauna"¹⁰, or in other words, it signifies any life form in any complexity, which possibly includes a river etc. as well.

N4 (Normative Standard) In this sense **nature** is considered to be a "*normative standard*"¹¹. This means that all one needs to do in order to figure out what should be done in any given situation is to turn to the "natural processes" and ask, "How would nature shape its path?".

The ambiguity of the concept of nature is primarily due to a collapse of N1 and N2 into one sense, while neither of the two are usable in environmental philosophy. If one commits to N1, then by definition there is nothing that can harm the nature, so all is well. However this is contrary to our intuition that there are environmental problems. From the opposite side, committing to N2 renders one's endeavor to remedy any environmental problem to be futile by definition. No matter what humans do, what they will produce will be nonhuman, so nature

⁷[Vog15, p. 117]

⁸[Vog15, p. 16]

⁹[Vog15, p. 12]

¹⁰[Vog15, p. 16]

¹¹[Vog15, p. 26]

won't be saved. But if environmental endeavors are by definition futile, then environmental philosophy would be nothing but tragic romanticism, which is infamously pointless¹². Also, just as in N1, it is intuitive that there is something—no matter how small—we can do to remedy environmental problems. It is better to not litter the street rather than litter it. Observe that, resorting to Aristotelean terminology, N1 mirrors excess in the state of character pertaining to the virtue of knowledge, while N2 mirrors excess in the state of character pertaining to the virtue of humility. In this framework it becomes apparent really that the two environmental virtues of Vogel are both pertaining to the same virtue, for which N1 and N2 denote the states most distant to the mean¹³.

N4 comes short of being substantial, since it is primarily used when saying, e.g., that one is closer to nature when one is at a farm, plowing the soil. However in urban areas there is still life: not only humans but broccolis, and bears. Also humans are never alone, at least in producing artifacts, that is, humans are always (already) transforming that which environs them, and we do so socially. Consequently one is never away from life, which renders N3 pointless. As for the final definition of nature, Vogel claims that it leads to "pretty dangerous ethical waters"¹⁴, since nature can hardly be said to be doing what is right, or good, in a stable manner. This is also a major problem in the deep ecology of Næss, and realizing that the above question "How would nature shape its path?" is peculiarly¹⁵ similar to the question "How would Jesus do?", Voltaire's opposition to religion (but not a God, mind you), comes into play with its full force:

[Voltaire's poem about the 1755 Lisbon Earthquake] ends with the brief story of a caliph who, after death, offers up to God all that he, in his immensity, does not have: deficiency, regrets, ill fortune, ignorance—and hope.¹⁶

It is clear why the concept of nature has to be dropped. But there is still hope for environmental endeavors, which can be regained by recognizing that humanity is alienated from its environment. It may indeed be futile to try to save the nature, in whichever definition one interprets it. Nevertheless, something can be saved, or we at least have hope of saving something, and that is the environment. The awakening from the alienation from the environment is equivalent to committing to the environmental virtues of knowledge and humility, and this also justifies that Vogel's philosophy is the next link to the land ethic in Leopold's ethical sequence:

[T]here's one more step possible in the extension—the move to artifacts, to the human-made things of this world, and to the question of *their* moral status.¹⁷

[M]alls might possess a similar sort of complexity and teleology as butterflies (although the *degree* of complexity may not be the same), and hence [...] might be said to possess something like interests and a

¹²The pointlessness I point to is in alignment with saying "this paper won't be as (philosophically and/or critically) complete as I would like to, so I would rather not write it at all, and not get an acceptable grade".

¹³[Ari98]

¹⁴[Vog15, p. 26]

¹⁵Conveniently, rather, on my part.

¹⁶[Vol08, p. xviii]

¹⁷[Vog15, p. 146]

good.¹⁸

Conclusion

In conclusion Vogel's philosophy boils down to two environmental virtues. By the virtue of knowledge we see ourselves as responsible for the environmental problems, viz. the (side-products of) badly-built artifacts. By the virtue of humility we realize that there will always be unintentional sideproducts of our artifacts, that "the world will always escape our ability to predict it"¹⁹. The citation from Robinson's *Tristram* Leopold uses now finds it proper place:

Gouvernail answered, looking at his reins,
 "[...]
 Youth sees too far to see how near it is
 To seeing farther. You are too blind today,
 By dim necessity of circumstance,
 More than to guess. Whether you take your crown
 In Lyonesse or not, you will be king
 Wherever you are. Many by chance are crowned
 As kings that are born rather to be tinkers,
 Or farmers, or philosophers, or farriers,
 Or barbers, or almost anything under God
 Than to be kings. Whether you will or not,
 You are a king, Tristram, for you are one
 Of the time-sifted few that leave the world,
 When they are gone, not the same place it was.
 Mark what you leave."²⁰

Realizing that humanity is the king is committing to the virtue of knowledge, where "king" of course has no connotation with the anthropocentric position of the conqueror of the universe Leopold criticizes. Realizing that humanity is blind is committing to the virtue of humility, although we may be ever-blind.

Perhaps Leopold used only the last two sentences I cite from *Tristram* unintentionally. I would like to think that this was not the case, that Leopold deliberately did not use the first part of my citation, since it would be a missed opportunity for him not to mention blindness. Except, citing the first part comes at a price, since Gouvernail (Robinson) places the king, who marks what he leaves, in opposition to the philosopher (among other things), which reminds one of Plato's philosopher king as the head of the state, and the problems associated to this idea²¹.

From another standpoint, didn't we have the intuition of these virtues (always) already? When a couple decides to make a baby, they realize that they should be prepared for what is to come. For a good education and a healthy childhood, the baby will need a considerable amount

¹⁸[Vog15, p. 158]

¹⁹[Vog15, p. 166]

²⁰[Rob27, p. 83]

²¹For instance, no true philosopher would be willing to take on the responsibilities and possibly the dirty works required of a king.

of money as well as a stable home and neighborhood, and the couple has the power to make adjustments to their budget accordingly. All the while the baby might be born defective, and there are times when there is nothing to do for the couple to avoid this. So it seems, Vogel only managed to bring us back to the starting line, and accordingly, all (environmental) philosophy so far is nothing but a very involved form of procrastination (of actually solving environmental problems).

To give an answer to this, all that is needed is to resort to the virtue of humility, provided that (environmental) philosophy is proper (environmental) practice: Talking of something called nature was the best thing we could do at the time, and we messed up, and now we are fixing it. In this sense Vogel's work is a philosophical restoration. Hence it suffices to justify why philosophy is proper practice. For this, recall the famous ending of *Candide*:

And sometimes Pangloss would say to Candide:

'All events form a chain in the best of all possible worlds. For in the end, if you had not been given a good kick up the backside and chased out of a beautiful castle for loving Miss Cunégonde, and if you hadn't been subjected to the Inquisition, and if you hadn't wandered about America on foot, and if you hadn't dealt the Baron a good blow with your sword, and if you hadn't lost all your sheep from that fine country of Eldorado, you wouldn't be here now eating candied citron and pistachio nuts.'

'That is well put,' replied Candide, 'but we must cultivate our garden.'²²

Now denote the chain of events by C and Candide's reply by G . Then we can write $C \implies G$, where $\implies$ denotes not necessarily causality in the logical sense, but has the weaker meaning of "leads to". In this notation, we actually have $C \implies (C \implies G)$, or more precisely,

$$C \implies ("C" \implies G).$$

We have certainly spent time and effort, testing whether our philosophies would work, and at the end we come to the conclusion they have not, to the extent that we ourselves could not see that they are not working (as demonstrated by the ambiguity of the concept of nature), but this is the price we had to pay in order to realize that cultivating our garden (actually solving environmental problems) is what matters, and not devising philosophies or testing them. Henceforth philosophy as philosophy undone is established as proper practice.

²²[Vol08, p. 88]

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